

Guidance for reviewers on the Review of Forest Stewardship Standards

Country Requirements Program | Performance and Standards Unit | FSC International | Bonn, Germany

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Note: this guidance is an unofficial document that aims to provide support for reviewers (assessors) of Forest Stewardship Standards (FSS) or Regional FSS. A separate guidance document will be developed for the reviewers of Interim Forest Stewardship Standards.

Introduction:

The role of the Standard Development Group is to “develop, maintain, review, revise, and interprets forest stewardship standards. Forest operations must adhere to the FSC Principles and Criteria through adapted national standards to be certified by FSC.”¹

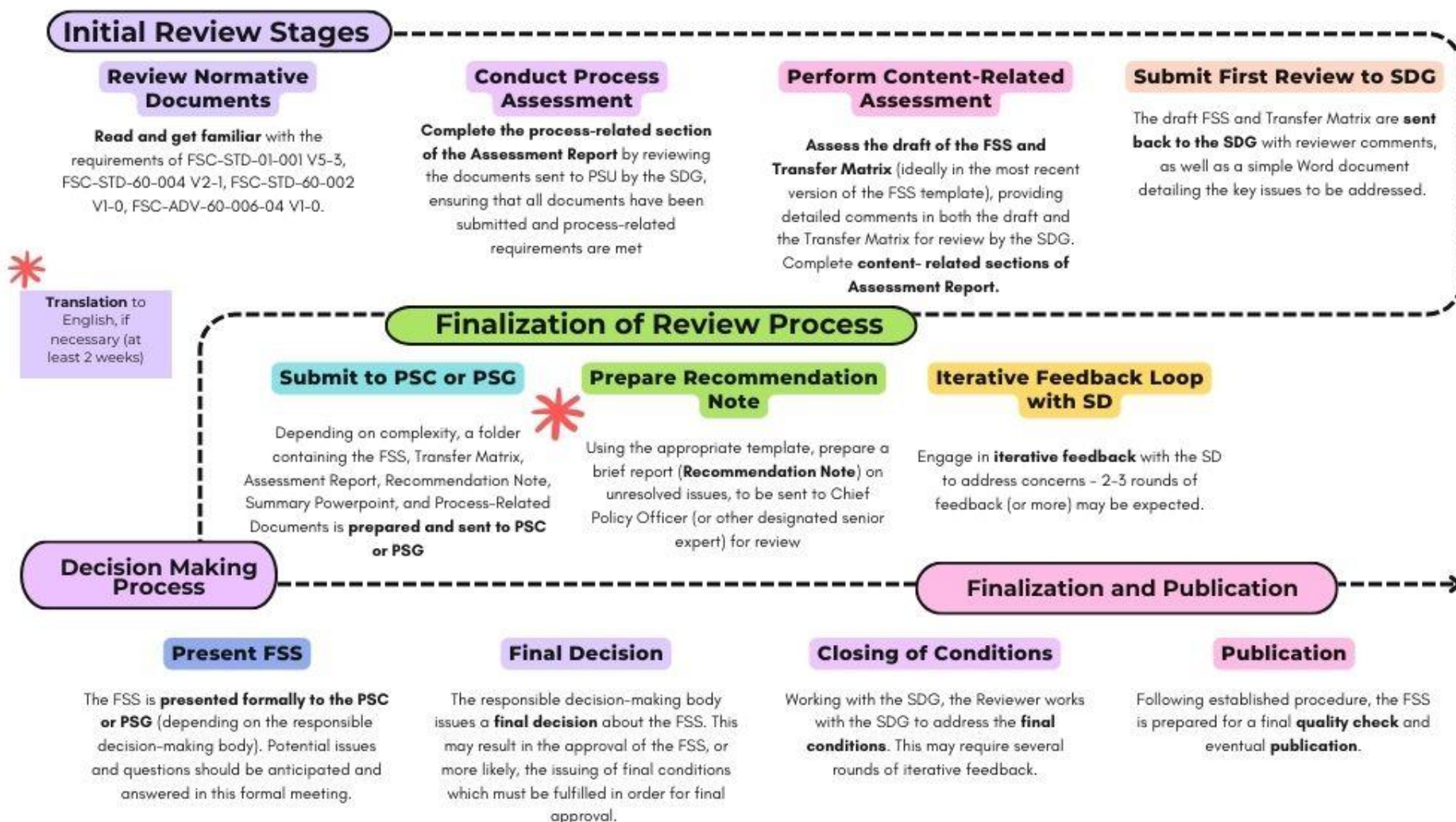
After a Forest Stewardship Standard (FSS) is developed at the national level, it is submitted to our team for detailed review. Practically speaking, this includes:

- **Detailed document review** – comparing the submitted FSS to the most recently approved versions of FSC normative documents, such as STD-60-004 (International Generic Indicators), and/or a country’s existing forest stewardship standards;
- **Reviewing and understanding the** justifications provided by Standard Development Groups (SDGs) for the adaptation or removal of elements (criteria, indicators) of the FSS;
- **Serving as the point of contact** between SDGs and FSC, providing guidance and interpretation where necessary;
- **Presenting the completed submission** of the standard to the Policy and Standards Committee (PSC) or the Policy Steering Group (PSG) for a final decision on the approval of the Standard.

¹ 1.1.5, Newcomer’s Guide, PSU,

<https://onefsc.sharepoint.com/sites/PSU/Shared%20Documents/Forms/AllItems.aspx?id=%2Fsites%2FPSU%2FShared%20Documents%2F0%5FReadMe%2FPSU%5FNewcomers%2DGuide%5F2023%2D01%2D31%2Epdf&viewid=140e9540%2Dde4e%2D4b3e%2Db87f%2De08e74044ae5&parent=%2Fsites%2FPSU%2FShared%20Documents%2F0%5FReadMe>

FSS Review Timeline



Background: Normative Documents and the Review Process

The following documents serve as the normative basis for the review process of Forest Stewardship Standards (FSS) (formerly National Forest Stewardship Standards, NFSS):

Document Name	Description
FSC-PRO-60-006 V2-0: Development and Transfer of National Forest Stewardship Standards to the FSC Principles and Criteria Version 5-1	This Procedure establishes the process for the development of new and transfer of existing Forest Stewardship Standard (FSS) to the P&C V5-1 (since 1 July 2023, P&C V5-3) and establishes how to use the IGI as a starting point in the process.
FSC-STD-60-006 (V1-2): Process Requirements for the Development and Maintenance of National Forest Stewardship Standards	This standard clarifies how within the FSC system the authority is given to develop Forest Stewardship Standards (including the responsibilities of relevant bodies), in line with FSC requirements. The standard gives FSC a stronger position to standardize, prioritize and harmonize the development of Forest Stewardship Standards.
FSC-STD-60-002: Structure and Content of National Forest Stewardship Standards	Provides a number of important components relating to the development of FSS and IFSS, including what kinds of information should be included in the Annexes of a standard, how standards should take account of Scale, Intensity ² , how indicators should be developed and numbered, as well as how standards should be translated and restructured.
FSC-ADV-60-006-02 V1-0: Advice Note on the Incorporation of New or Revised IGIs	Provides advice on whether (and when) new or revised IGIs should be incorporated into a FSS or IFSS depending on the status of the revision process
FSC-PRO-10-606 V2-2: Approval of Forest Stewardship Standards	Describes the internal processes of PSU and the PSC for deciding on the approval of a FSS – including a list of documents which PSU must submit to the PSC, and templates which the PSC uses to record their decisions

For FSS, the International Generic Indicators (along with other documents, described in detail below in “Development” and “Assessment” sections) broadly serve as the starting point for standard developer groups to develop their forestry standards. The IGIs, in turn, are based on (and organized according to) the FSC Principles and Criteria, making it possible for certification bodies to clearly assess and audit whether or not Organizations have met these Principles and Criteria. The IGIs and other international normative documents are maintained and revised by the Forest Management (FM) team of PSU.

Determining whether an IGI is incorporated into a national standard depends on several factors. While IGIs serve as the basis of national standards, Standard Developers (SDs) may **adapt, adopt, drop, split, or borrow** (i.e. include) indicators (from another approved FSS).³ Additionally, it also depends on where a country is in their process of developing a national standard (as sometimes, this timeline can be quite long), and whether or not an IGI is new or revised since the publication of a previous national standard. In this case, an Advice Note ([ADV-60-006-02](#)) clarifies:

- If a national standard is in development or revision at the time that a new version of the IGIs (STD-60-004) is published, and they are **prior** to the launch of the first consultation

² This is also addressed in greater detail in FSC-GUI-60-002, which provides Guidance to Standard Developers on incorporating/developing indicators for the purposes of addressing Scale, Intensity, and Risk in Standards.

³ See [STD-60-006](#), Process Requirements for the Development and Maintenance of NFSS for more detail.

period, they should address new or revised IGIs in their revised standard (by either adopting them, or adapting them/dropping them/splitting them as well as providing justification for these changes).

- If a national standard is **not** in the development/revision process, or has **already passed** the launch of the first consultation, then the changes to the IGIs should be addressed in the next scheduled review.

Registration and development of an FSS

The following documents are essential to the development/revision process, and should be shared with standard developers before the FSS development starts:

- [Registration application template](#)
- [FSS template](#)
- [Transfer Matrix template](#)
- [Document Control](#)

See Figure 1. The FSS Process (from FSC-STD-60-006). Figure 1 below for an overview of the FSS Process.

Registration

Initially, a Coordinator of a Standard Development Group (SDG) or other responsible person for the development or revision (scheduled or unscheduled) of a standard (for instance, a staff member of a National Office)⁴ submits the request for registration to PSU. The registration request has to be submitted on the basis of a special [template](#) (mentioned above).

The PSU reviewer responsible for the FSS must review the application. The reviewer then provides feedback to the standard developer (SD) on the application documents. The feedback shall include the request to add missing information or correct those elements that are not in line with relevant requirements (e.g. FSC-STD-60-006, [Process Requirements for the Development and Maintenance of National Forest Stewardship Standards](#)), if applicable.

⁴ For more information on the formation of SDGs, this internal document developed by PSU may provide additional details: [How Are SDGs Formed?](#)

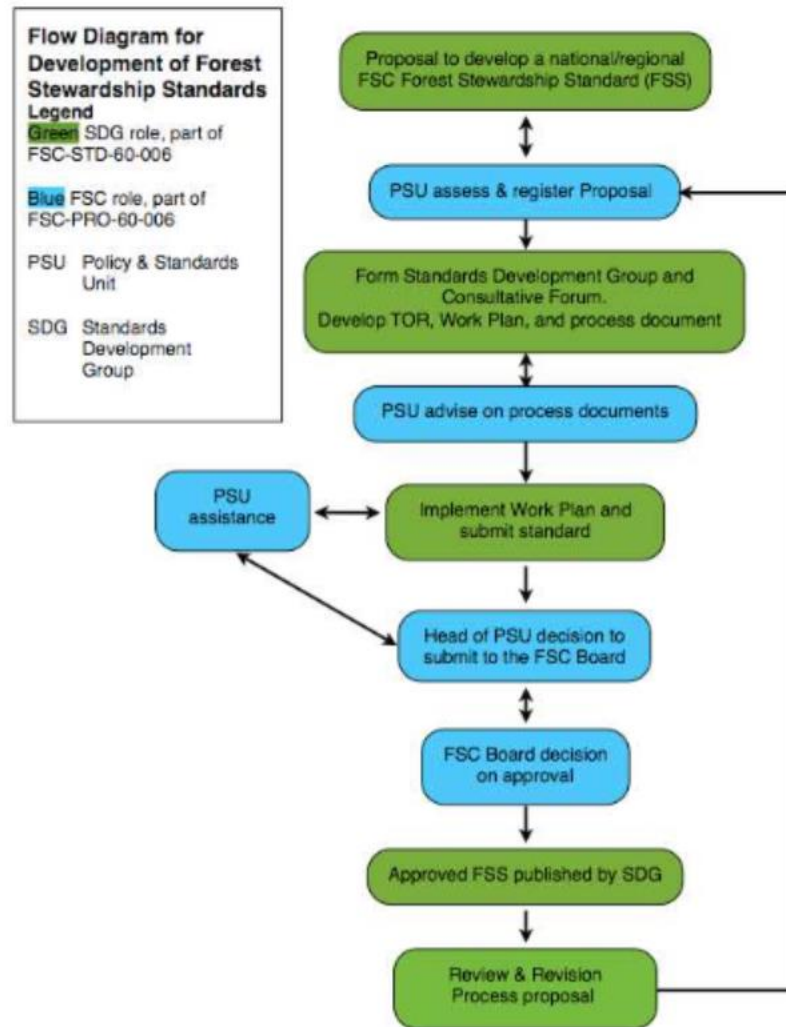


Figure 1. The FSS Process (from FSC-STD-60-006).

Once all those requests have been met (to the quality level satisfactory for the reviewer), the reviewer forwards the document to the System Performance Director of PSU.⁵ The Director reviews the document and might identify some further elements in the application that need improvement. After all those issues are addressed by the reviewer and SD, the Director approves the application. That is the formal registration of the FSS development by PSU.

Only after the PSU registration can the actual FSS development officially start.

Further details of assessment of registration requests

⁵ Currently Joanna Nowakowska.

The reviewer goes through each section of the application/request for registration. All mandatory fields of the template have to be properly filled out by the applicant. Here, “properly” means that the applicant must provide information with sufficient detail and clarity while also avoiding lengthy text.

Some parts will have to be completed by the PSU reviewer, while most of the template will have to be filled in by the applicant. The template makes it clear which part is to be completed by whom.

Particular attention must be given to Sections 1.4 (including the scope of the standard to be developed or revised), 1.6 (budget), 2.1 (work plan), 2.3 (SDG composition), 2.6 (forest testing, if applicable) and annexes related to privacy statement, data processing agreement and photo consents.

Based on our experience, a few rounds of exchanges of feedback will probably be needed between the reviewer and applicant before the document is ready to be forwarded to the System Performances Director for final review and approval. The Director might also identify a few more elements that need further improvement before the application document is finally approved.

Development

During the development of a FSS, the reviewer must remain in contact with the SD. This is to ensure that the process runs smoothly. If any serious issue is identified by the SD that needs PSU support, the reviewer should be notified immediately, and relevant measures must be taken.

Quarterly reports are provided by all the SD during the process. Those reports are received and analyzed by a student assistant that works for the Country Requirements Program. Apart from the overall update about the FSS development process, the reports should also mention any serious problem that might be encountered and whether PSU support is needed.

During the FSS development process, it is possible that significant delays occur for various reasons. In such cases, the SD has to send a formal request to PSU for approval of the extension of the respective timelines. Like initial registration, this request has to be submitted in a [special template](#) (to be sent to the SD by the reviewer immediately after the notification has been received from the former about the need for the deadline extension) and include relevant clarifications and justifications and proposed new timelines. The request for timeline extension is reviewed by the System Performance Director and if the SD justifications are acceptable, approves it.

Assessment

Process-related assessment

As the initial step, reviewers need to read the above-mentioned normative documents, which form the bases for the process-related requirements for FSS development.

Once the standard is submitted to the responsible reviewer at the PSU, the review starts. Usually, it has to start from the **process review** – whether all essential steps required by the procedures listed above, have been implemented.

The main document that the reviewer has to complete is the [assessment report](#). All essential process-related requirements (checklists based on respective normative documents) are listed in that document.

The reviewer has to check whether:

- all process steps outlined in the original application document (see above) have been properly conducted and
- all mandatory documents listed in the [document control](#) file, have been submitted.

All missing documents or information have to be requested by the reviewer from the SD. The latter either submits this missing information/documents or provides sufficient justification for their absence.

Once the process-related part of the assessment is completed, the content assessment of the standard starts.

Further details on the process-related assessment

The process-related assessment starts with completing the [assessment report](#). The document is mainly a checklist that includes all relevant requirements (clauses) of [FSC-STD-60-006](#). It also includes a relatively brief checklist of content-related requirements in the final pages based on [FSC-STD-60-002](#) (in Checklist 1 in this document, this is listed as ‘Item 8 – Content’, with the full checklist following on the next page).

The reviewer goes through the checklist, clause by clause, and checks whether respective requirements have been met, partly met, or not met. The main source of information for that purpose is the set of documents submitted by the SDG together with the standard (e.g., consultative forum list, field test report summary, SDG motion, summary report about the entire process prepared by the SDG, evidence of announcements of the process and public consultations, etc.).

Example:

See an annotated version of the Checklist for the review of China’s FSS here. The left column lists the requirement, and the column for PSU’s commentary includes the text “Requirement satisfactorily met” (or alternatively, not met.). The comments provided for each item explain how the conclusion was reached that the requirement was satisfactorily met, the file path of the file (submitted by the SDG) that serves as proof of the requirement having been satisfactorily met, as well as questions that arose during the review process (as well as their answers, reached in consultation with other staff in PSU).

For all those requirements that were not fully met, the reviewer sends requests to the standard developer to either: a) submit the missing information or b) provide sufficient and legitimate justification for not meeting those requirements. This request can be sent in a simple Word document (or in any other format preferred by the reviewer) with the listed outstanding issues and requested action points (or justifications) from the SD.

If the SD fails to provide missing information or sufficient justification, the reviewer discusses the issue further with the Chief Policy Officer (CPO) of PSU⁶. If necessary, the issue(s) is flagged for the attention of PSC.

If the failure to meet respective requirement is substantial (e.g. not conducting a field test, when such a test was mandatory), the reviewer, on behalf of PSU, should request the implementation of further activities from the SDG (e.g. field test, additional public consultation), in order to fill those process gaps and re-submit the standard to PSU.

Once all essential process-related requirements are met (including through the submission by the SDG of all missing documents and information), the content assessment can be started.

Process review of FSS based on P&CV5 that underwent scheduled revisions

The process-related requirements for FSS based on P&C V5 (and IGI) that undergo scheduled revisions are outlined in Section 12.5 (“Approved Departures from Procedures”) of [FSC-STD-60-006](#). The review of

⁶ Currently, Hans Joachim (“Achim”) Droste

process-related documents shall therefore be based on those provisions. In other words, if a SD intends to omit any of the steps of a FSS development during the scheduled revision of the standard, this has to be clearly indicated in the application for scheduled revision, together with relevant rationale. PSU will then review this rationale and decide, whether acceptable or not.

During the review of process-related aspects of a standard revised by means of scheduled revision, it has therefore to be checked, whether the SD completed all steps agreed upon (between the SD and PSU) and included in the application document mentioned above.

Content-related assessment of FSS

Normative bases for content- related assessments of FSS:

[FSC-STD-01-001 V5-3: FSC Principles and Criteria](#)

[FSC-STD-60-004 V2-1: International Generic Indicators](#)

[FSC-STD-60-002 V1-0: Structure and Content of National Forest Stewardship Standards](#)

[FSC-ADV-60-006-04 V1-0: Advice Note on the Incorporation of New or Revised IGIs into Future Versions of NFSS and IFSS](#)

As the initial step, reviewers need to read the above-mentioned normative documents, which form the bases for the content-related requirements for FSS development.

Note on New Versions of Templates: In cases where the SD may have inadvertently used an older template (e.g. when they submitted their proposed standard right as a new template is being developed), it will be *voluntary* for them to adopt the new template however, we should offer them the possibility to reformat using the newest version (for consistency's sake). In any case, the draft standard will be moved to the new template by PSU in our quality review checks.

The content-related part involves the assessment of two major documents – the FSS itself and the Transfer Matrix. As already mentioned, the templates [for FSS](#) and for the [Transfer Matrix \(TM\)](#) (together with other documents and templates) must be sent to SD before the process starts. It is important to ensure that SDGs are using the most current version of the template when developing and drafting their FSS. The SD have to use the FSS template for the standard development and, in addition, fill in the Transfer Matrix (TM).

Based on Section 2.1 of FSC-STD-60-006, the IGI together with the Instructions for Standards Developers and the Annexes shall be used as the starting point for the development and transfer of FSS. In this regard, main purpose of the TM is to clearly demonstrate which IGIs (or other indicators of a FSS) have been adopted, adapted, or dropped, in addition to whether new indicators have been added. Also, note that any modification of the IGIs (slight or strong modification) is considered an adaptation. The action taken against the indicator in the TM should align with the FSC definition (as per Sections 2.1 and 2.2 of FSC-PRO-60-006) of adopted, adapted, dropped or new indicator added. The SD must also provide justifications on why changes were made to existing indicators or new indicators added. For that purpose, the TM includes specific columns.

When reviewing the TM, the reviewer (on behalf of PSU) must provide feedback – whether indicators in the standard under review are acceptable. If not, rationale must be provided alongside with the requested modifications from the SD. **See Section below with further instructions on how to assess a Transfer Matrix.**

The SD then provides further information on how they followed up on PSU request in column(s) added to the right (to PSU columns) in the respective sheet of the TM. PSU then provides further feedback (in a further added column) and so on, until all requests of PSU have been met.

On those elements of the FSS for which no agreement has been reached between the reviewer and SD, and that do not clearly contradict FSC normative requirements, the reviewer prepares a brief report for Policy and Standards Committee (PSC). The report on specific issues has to be included in the Recommendation Note and describe the key points of disagreement, SD rationale, reviewer (i.e. PSU) reflections and request to PSC for the relevant decision.

Carrying out the content-related assessment (further details)

In order to save the time needed for FSS and TM assessment in general, it is recommended that the reviewer **starts the review with the FSS draft**. Specifically, all initial sections of a standard as well as the Annexes could be reviewed first. Principles, Criteria and indicators section of the FSS can be omitted by the reviewer at that stage, since the indicators are to be reviewed in detail in the TM. The only exception is guidance or applicability notes (or other provisions listed in the P&C and indicators section of the FSS), which might be included in the FSS but not in the TM. In that case, those notes and other respective information (except P&C and indicators) have to be checked, to make sure that they are in line with FSC's respective normative requirements (for instance, notes shall not include normative requirements).

The standard shall include the wording of each FSC Principle and each FSC Criterion in the same order as they occur in the current version of FSC-STD-01-001 FSC Principles and Criteria of Forest Stewardship. Additional criteria which are not part of FSC-STD-01-001 may be added to the standard (with clear justification by the standard developer) according to Section 3, Clause 3.2 of FSC-STD-60-002. An explanation shall be provided if any Criterion is considered to be inapplicable in a given situation. That explanation shall not conflict with respective FSC normative framework (Clause 3.3 of FSC-STD-60-002).

Once the FSS (except P&C and indicators) has been reviewed, the reviewer sends the document to the SD, with feedback in the form of relevant comments and proposed amendments in track changes. While the SD works to address the reviewer feedback on the FSS, the reviewer starts the assessment of the TM.

As mentioned above, the main purpose of the TM is to facilitate the assessment of whether the adaptation or drop of an IGI (or addition of new indicators) and respective justifications of the SD are acceptable for PSU or not. For this purpose, reviewers are particularly required to use the provisions outlined in Sections 2.2 and 2.3 of FSC-PRO-60-006 as the bases to decide, whether modifications to IGI or adding new indicators are acceptable. If not acceptable, PSU must provide relevant explanation and rationale and provide a clear request to the SD on what needs to be done, to address the issue to the satisfaction of PSU.

The review is completed once all indicators have been agreed in the TM (regarding the few possible indicators/issues that might not be fully agreed at that stage, see the section "Content-related assessment of FSS" above).

Usually 3-4 rounds of communication and feedback are needed between the SD and PSU, until the standard is ready for the review by the CPO and, eventually, PSC/PSG. The number of rounds can be lower or higher, depending on the complexity of a standard (see below the section on timelines for further details).

At the final stage of assessment, the SD shall make sure that the formulations of indicators and notes (and all other relevant provisions) are identical in the TM and FSS. The reviewer shall also cross check whether that is the case, once the review of TM is completed.

Special attention has to be given to the translation needs. If, for instance, the standard is developed in Spanish or French, its English translation has to be developed for PSC assessment on time. For this purpose, at least two calendar weeks have to be allocated for the translation. This time period has to be included within the respective timeline (see below) and agreed with the SD as well as the translator as early as possible (e.g. preferably at least two months before the document is ready for translation).

The actual request for translation has to be submitted by the reviewer via FSC SAP/ERP, at least one week before the actual translation starts (but preferably earlier). Further details will be provided to new reviewers in due course.

The reviewers might also find the following [guidance document](#) helpful. It was developed in 2021 in cooperation with PSC and Forest Management Community (Forest Network at that time), with the aim to support standard developers tackle some of the IGIs or requirements perceived as difficult or problematic.

Content review of FSS based on P&CV5 that underwent scheduled revisions

Based on Section 2.1 of FSC-STD-60-006, the IGI shall be used as the starting point for the development and transfer of FSS. That requirement applies to those standards that undergo the transfer from P&C V4 to V5.

In case of review of standards that were already based on P&C V5 (and IGIs) and underwent scheduled revisions, a different rule applies. That rule is outlined in the Advice note [ADVICE-60-006-04](#) (V1-0) EN. Specifically, SDs shall use as a starting point:

- All indicators in their valid FSS, and
- All new and revised IGIs which were not addressed in their valid FSS.

SDs shall use the indicators of their approved FSS as the starting point of the revision as follows:

- Adopting an existing indicator from the FSS; does not require justification
- Adapting or dropping an existing indicator from the FSS; requires justification
- Adding new indicators; requires justification

SDs shall use the new and revised IGIs as the starting point of the revision as follows:

- Adopting an IGI does not require justification
- Adapting or dropping an IGI requires justification.

Further details are available in the Advice note. The reviewer shall therefore make sure that all above-mentioned requirements have been met by the SD. The TM that has to be used for the development and review of standards that undergo scheduled revisions (from P&C V5 to V5) and that includes all necessary instructions, is available [here \(link to be added\)](#).

For a checklist of things to pay special attention to in a review, see the section below (this document).

The Transfer Matrix

The Transfer Matrix is a tool developed in Excel which allows for the comparison of proposed indicators in an FSS Standard with the IGIs (and, in the case of scheduled revisions, proposed indicators in the new draft standard vs those of the currently valid standard). A similar tool is also used for IFSS Reviews, and is known as the “Adaptation Record”.

The Transfer Matrix is organized by Principles and Criteria, and contains columns with information on:

- The current text of the IGI (new edits/revisions to the IGI are marked in **red**);
- The current text of the Indicator in the most recent valid FSS Standard (if applicable);
- The text of the proposed indicators;
- Whether or not indicators have been “adapted”, “adopted”, “dropped”, or “added”;
- SDG justifications (necessary in all cases apart from “adoption”); and
- PSU assessment.

The Transfer Matrix is a key document submitted by SDGs for review by PSU. The responsibility of PSU reviewers is therefore to provide the relevant template of a Transfer Matrix to SDGs in the initial process of development of a FSS. The Reviewer’s responsibilities when assessing the Transfer Matrix include:

1. **Verifying** that the text of the proposed indicators and notes in the draft text of the Standard match exactly with what is in the Transfer Matrix. Occasionally, SDGs make mistakes by including text in the draft of the standard, but not in the Transfer Matrix, or vice versa. If this happens, flag it and ask the SDG to include the missing information and/or adjust the document(s) for consistency.
2. **Assessing** the appropriateness of the proposed indicator (based on FSC’s normative framework),
3. **Checking** that the appropriate selection has been made for “Adoption”, “Adaptation”, “Dropped”, or “Added”. For revision processes, checking this may be a bit more complex – see figure below.
4. **Providing feedback** in the PSU assessment column.

Timeline and Communications with SDG

Once the FSS has been submitted to PSU and the review starts, a timeline has to be agreed between the SD and PSU. The timeline shall include the following elements:

- Date of submission of the first feedback of PSU to the SD on the TM⁷; the development of this initial feedback by PSU on the TM usually takes around 2-3 calendar weeks or more, depending on the available time and complexity of the standard
- Date of response of the SD on the first PSU feedback (for both, FSS and TM) - this usually takes up to one month
- Date of submission of the second round of feedback by the PSU
- Date of the response of the SD (and so on, until the standard is ready for the review by the CPO)
- Final and intensive back-and-forth communication between the SD and PSU
- Review of the standard by the CPO (this stage needs at least two weeks; the following documents have to be submitted to the CPO: FSS, TM and Recommendation Note)
- Addressing the feedback of CPO by the reviewer and, if needed by the SD
- Once the CPO provides “no objection”, submission of the FSS to PSC/PSG⁸

Examples of such timelines agreed earlier can be provided for new reviewers.

Important: To ensure that the Process Portfolio Manager⁹ is apprised of all developments related to the revision process (and can track them in our system), please keep two email addresses in the CC field in all relevant email with the SDG and the Chief Policy Officer¹⁰. The emails are: nationalstandards@fsc.org and country_requirements@fsc.org. These email accounts are checked by the Process Portfolio Manager and the Programme Manager of Country Reviews regularly.

Relevant communications might include when you submit a Recommendation note, return a draft of a standard to the SDG, return a round of feedback for Closing Conditions, or similar – anything with a date stamp of a milestone relevant to the revision process.

Additionally, email communications with SDGs should be organized in such a way that key dates, decisions, and project milestones are easy to find and reference.

Failed Processes

Failed processes occur when SDGs fail to reach a consensus about the adoption or adaptation of the IGIs. A failed process is usually only declared for processes that are extremely behind schedule and show little movement towards progress.

In the event of a failed process, the SDG will be formally de-registered. To confirm this deregistration, an official letter is sent by PSU addressed to the SDG coordinator as well as the members of the Standard Development Group. An example of such a letter can be [found here](#).

Internal Peer Review

In order to enhance the quality of content-related assessments of FSS, Country requirements team has established the practice of internal peer review of standards. This involves a peer review of the respective

⁷ As mentioned above, it is recommended that a reviewer starts the review with FSS assessment. That usually takes 2-3 days, unless the standard is highly complex. Consequently, by the time when the PSU provides the initial feedback on TM, the SD has already received the feedback on the FSS a few days ago; consequently, the SD can later provide their response to PSU feedback on both, the FSS and TM.

⁸ The FSS and associated documents have to be submitted at least four weeks before the first day of relevant PSC meeting. For PSG, this can be reduced to two weeks (at the very least, one week; **TBC with Juliana**).

⁹ Currently, Dori Pavloska

¹⁰ Achim

standard (already reviewed by the main reviewer) by another reviewer. This peer review can involve the entire standard or parts of it (e.g. selected Principles), considering the availability of time.

Calibration Notes

The Country requirements team has developed, maintains and periodically updates the so-called [calibration notes](#) document. In this document, the team members include questions which cannot be easily answered by existing normative documents, advice notes or interpretations. Those questions are discussed (during the regular bi-monthly calibration calls) with the Chief Policy Officer.

The developed and agreed responses are maintained in the document. The main function of this document is therefore to keep all relevant process and content-related (basically ad-hoc) Q&A and, in this way, avoid repeated discussions of same issues.

Complexity of an FSS

The FSS are divided into two categories, based on the so-called complexity criteria. Those criteria are available in the internal procedure [FSC-PRO-10-607a](#). High-complexity FSS shall be assessed by the PSC and low-complexity standards – by the Policy Steering Group, PSG. The documents required under each scenario and described below.

Documents to be submitted to PSC – as a result of the review, the reviewer prepares two folders for PSC – for *Key documents* and for *Supplementary documents*. The key documents include:

- FSS Draft,
- Transfer Matrix,
- Assessment report and
- Recommendation Note.

The latter provides summary on the process- and contents-related aspects of the FSS development and lists the issues (usually disagreements with the SD) that are for a particular attention of PSC. The supplementary documents folder mainly includes the information related to the process of development of a FSS (field test report, consultative forum list, brief analysis of public consultation results, SDG motion of submission of a FSS to PSU and other documents listed in the document control checklist.

Documents to be submitted to PSG – the reviewer prepares one folder that includes all the documents listed below:

- [FSS](#)
- Transfer Matrix
- Assessment report
- Recommendation Note
- PowerPoint presentation that summarizes relevant information
- Process-related documents (similar to those listed in the supplementary folder for PSC)

The link to the [inventory of templates](#) can be found here.

Possible outcomes of PSC/PSG assessment

There are basically three possible outcomes of PSC assessment of a FSS:

- Approval of the FSS with conditions (the most frequent outcome)
- Approval without any condition;
- Deferral to the FSC Board of Directors.
- No approval - returning the standard to the SD for further work.

The next steps in case of the conditional approval are outlined below. In the case of unconditional approval, the standard goes directly to publication. In the case of no approval, the standard goes back to the SD for further work (via PSU) in order to address the drawbacks identified by PSC, before resubmission of the standard to the latter.

Reviewing the past decisions of the PSC may be helpful for understanding their rationale behind approval setting of conditions, or rejection of standards. A compilation of some of these decisions can be found [here](#).

A. PSC Approves FSS	1. Inform the Standard Development Group (SDG) coordinator (or other responsible person in the country/region), copying the respective Regional Director, of the decision of the PSC, sending a Decision Form signed off by the PSC and the approved FSS. 2. Assign document code and effective date of the FSS. 3. Assign the effective date of the standard in agreement with the standard developer. 4. Publish the standard on the FSC website. 5. Inform Certification Bodies operating in the region/country of the decision made by the PSC. 6. Inform Network partners of the decision made by the PSC. 7. Update FSC standards database with the recent version of the standard. 8. Publish approved standard on the FSC FSS webpage.
B. PSC Approves FSS with conditions	PSU reviewer initiates the following steps: 1. Inform the SDG coordinator (or other responsible person in the country/region) of the decision of the PSC, copying the respective Regional Director, of the decision of the PSC, sending a Decision Form signed off by the PSC and the approved FSS. 2. Inform Network partners of the decision made by the PSC. 3. Update FSC national standard database with the recent version of the standard. 4. Follow up with SDG on closing PSC conditions.
C. After the PSC conditions have been satisfactorily addressed	The FSC Chief Policy Officer shall review the latest version of the FSS following the addressing of all PSC conditions to the satisfactory level for the relevant PSU reviewer. Once the CPO approves the closure of all conditions, the PSU reviewer requests formal confirmations from all the SDG members (and National Board members if such exists in the respective country, or the Chair of NB on behalf of the members) that they accept the respective latest version of the standard. Only after such confirmations are received from all relevant persons, can the standard be qualified as a finally (and formally) approved.
D. The PSC defers decision on FSS to the FSC Board of Directors	The PSU reviewer shall do the following: 1. Inform the SDG coordinator (and other respective persons in the country) of the decision to defer the FSS to the FSC Board of Directors. 2. When decision has been made by the FSC Board, the PSU reviewer shall initiate either section (A) or (B) as appropriate.

Figure 2. Adapted from [Standard Operating Procedure Post National Forest Stewardship Standard PSC Decision Meeting](#). 2016 (Internal – Non-normative document).

Closure of approval of conditions (further details)

In case of conditional approval of the standard, the reviewer communicates the result (and the relevant approval conditions) to the SD and agrees on timelines for condition closure (in a similar way as for the review of the standard). For closure of conditions, a special [template](#) is used.

For more detailed notes on the closure of approval conditions, you can check the following [Notes](#) document here.

In an absolute majority of cases, PSC assigns the authority to close approval conditions to the Chief Policy Officer (CPO) of PSU.

In situations where the PSC is unable to reach a consensus decision on approval of the FSS, the PSC shall defer the decision-making process to the Board of Directors. The PSC shall request that the Board of Directors provide direction to the PSC on how to address specific issues identified by the PSC and, with Board guidance, allow the PSC to continue deliberation on the standard; or take responsibility for decision-making on the standard from the PSC.

The reviewer therefore works with the SDG (through the SD) to close all conditions and then forwards the updated standard and respective information to the Chief Policy Officer (CPO). The latter might identify some further issues that have to be addressed by the SDG. Once the CPO closes all conditions, the next step is to get formal confirmations from the SDG (and a National Board, if existing in the respective country, or a Chair of that Board, on behalf of all the members) that they accept the latest version of the standard. The reviewer is responsible for obtaining those confirmations. Once this is done, the standard is finally and formally approved and goes to publication.

Communications for FSS Approvals:

Communications activities (e.g. quality check and publication of Standards) is also undertaken by PSU. This may be a Policy Officer/Country Requirements Manager, Student Assistant, Officer, or other qualified individual in PSU. A step by-step guide to the Communications process, including instructions and relevant templates, may be found here: [Instructions & Templates: Communications on FSS approvals](#).

Preparing the FSS draft for Quality Check:

1. Create a copy of Approved FSS draft in folder D-Approval-Cond/Final/Draft-Approved-noQC.
2. Change the Status of this Draft to Approved.
3. Include the Approval date, expectation for Publication date (2 months after approval date on Tuesdays) and Effective date (3 months after publication date and always on 1st or 15th).
4. Make sure that all Principles and Criteria are there, including those which are not applicable (in case of IFSS)
5. Make sure that all approved indicators are there, and double-check the numbering.
6. Make a list of all new terms added by the SD.
7. Check some typos and grammar, including the addition of double spaces between words (see additional tips below)
8. Include some comments for Policy Officer attention, .e.g., new version of general wording, wrong acronyms (NFSS instead of FSS¹¹), and other considerations.
9. Send the link to the responsible Reviewer to start the QC.

Quality Check Fundamental rules:

1. Create a copy of Approved FSS draft in folder E-Finally-Approv/QC
2. Align the draft with last version of FSS Template.¹²

¹¹ Previously, Forest Stewardship Standards were known as “NFSS” (National Forest Stewardship Standards) in order to distinguish them from Interim Forest Stewardship Standards. However, the convention has recently changed , with “FSS” (Forest Stewardship Standards) replacing NFSS. The reasons for this are largely to avoid conflict of a political nature (for example, where a certain “Nation” is not recognized by another).

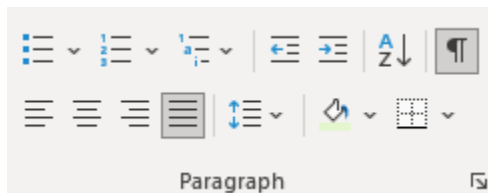
¹² This is only mandatory for FSS that have undergone scheduled revisions from Version 4 of the Principles and Criteria to Version 5. In all other cases, it is not mandatory, but ideal.

3. Make sure that all Principles, Criteria, indicators, notes and verifiers, list, are formatted with the right styles. (See Example below).
NOTE: in the [latest template](#) is already configured in the style for each FSS items.
4. New terms added (national terms) and defined in the FSS should be marked with an asterisk and formatted in italics at the indicator level.
5. The Official FSC terms of the Glossary shall be marked with an asterisk and formatted in italics only in the P&C level.
6. Each principle always starts on a new page.
7. Indicators should not be divided between two different pages unless they are too long. They should usually be placed on the next page.
8. A Criterion cannot be the last text at the end of a page - rather, the last text on the page should be the indicator or any notes. If you find a Criterion, then please place it in the next page.
9. The person in charge of the Quality Control should correct typos, but any changes in indicators wording must be aligned with the Manager, and in such case with PSU-CPO.
10. Changes in the wording of P&C are not allowed.
11. Changes in the wording of general content must be aligned with the Manager (or Reviewer of the Standard) and additionally with the PSU-CPO.
12. **To ensure consistency with all other FSC documents**, please refer to the [Editorial Style Guidelines](#), which contains important information regarding spelling and grammar conventions as well as FSC-brand specific information.

Tips: In order to ensure consistency throughout the QC process, it is best to ensure during the final stages of the review process that different sections and kinds of text (Principles, Criteria, Indicators, etc.) are in the same kinds of Document Styles.

Additionally, consider using ctrl + f (“Find” function in MS Word) to go through the document to correct errors of a similar type. Advanced ctrl + f features include searching and replacing by formatting and/or Document styles.

Finally, consider turning on the “show Paragraph marks” function in MS Word (see below) in order to see all formatting marks in the Standard. This makes certain errors (such as multiple spaces added between words) more obvious and easier to correct.



For further guidance, please feel free to reach out to Olea.

Example:

PRINCIPLE* 1: COMPLIANCE WITH LAWS¹³

*The Organization** shall comply with all *applicable laws**, regulations and *nationally ratified** international treaties, conventions and agreements.

1.1 ¹⁴*The Organization shall be a legally defined entity with clear, documented, and unchallenged *legal registration**, with written authorization from the *legally competent** authority for specific activities.¹⁵**

1.1.1¹⁶ Legal registration to carry out all activities within the scope of the certificate is documented and unchallenged.¹⁷

1.1.2 Legal registration is granted by a legally competent authority according to legally prescribed processes.

SLIMF 1.1.2 [In case there is an additional indicator suggested for SLIMF cases, it is included below the associated indicator, and aligned in the same way]

Verifiers:¹⁸ Copies of legal registration documents showing issuing authority.¹⁹

Applicability Note: [In cases where there is an applicability note, it would go here and be formatted like this. Note that Notes are NOT normative!]

¹⁴ The **Criteria** numbering is aligned with the text of the Principle, and is followed by a single indent (tab space)

¹⁵ The text of the **Criteria** is just as it appears in the IGLs – Bold, Arial, size 11. Key words (e.g. “The Organization”) are in *italics* and followed by an asterisk (*) to indicate that the term is further defined in the Glossary of Terms.

¹⁶ The numbering of the **Indicator** is aligned with the text of the preceding Criteria and followed by a single indent (Tab space).

¹⁷ The text of the indicator does *not* include terms in italics or followed by an asterisk (as they are in the IGLs).

¹⁸ **Verifiers** (if any) are marked by Verifiers (Bold, Arial, 11, aligned with the numbering of the Indicator above).

¹⁹ The text of the verifiers are in Regular, Arial, 11 – if there are multiple Verifiers, these are set off by semicolons (Verifier 1; Verifier 2).

Publication

The publication involves the following key steps:

- Agreeing upon the publication date and effectiveness date of the FSS with the SD
- Reviewing communication items developed by the SD and respective Policy Officer
- Signing consent forms for the photos that are included in the FSS (coordinated by the Policy Officer)
- Final quality check of the standard itself (in cooperation with the Policy Officer; see above)
- Uploading on the FSC International document center (coordinated by the Policy Officer)
- Release of the communication items (coordinated by the Policy Officer).

Implementation of the FSS

Once the standard is published, the SD and respective Network Partner (if existing) conduct calibration meetings with certificate holders, certification bodies and other key stakeholders in a respective country or region. The aim of those meetings is to ensure the same understanding of the standard requirements among those parties and facilitate its implementation.

Further reading

Below are listed the further normative documents related to the FSS development and implementation. The reviewers have to read these documents as well, once they have read the essential normative requirements listed above.

FSC-POL-20-003	FSC Policy on the Excision of Areas from the Scope of Certification
FSC-POL-30-001	FSC Pesticides Policy
FSC-STD-20-007	Forest Management Evaluations
FSC-STD-30-005	FSC Standard for Group Entities in Forest Management Groups
<u>FSC-DIR-20-007</u>	FSC Directive on FSC Forest Management Evaluations – Combines a number of Advice note relating to various topics, especially Forest Conversion. (Attention should be paid specifically Advice notes #1, 5, 6, 7, 8, 10, 13, 15, 17, 18, 21, 22 and 23)
FSC-GUI-30-003	FSC Guidelines for the implementation of the right to Free, Prior and Informed Consent (FPIC)
FSC-GUI-60-005	Promoting Gender Equality in National Forest Stewardship Standards

Review Checklist

Beginning of Standard:

Context of Standard:

The context should be a 1-2 page summary of the current state of the forestry industry in the country, as well as a summary of other information relative to the geography, biodiversity, and demography. The context of the standard should include a few sentences on each of the following topics, if possible and/or feasible:

Geographical and Environmental Description - Location of the country and its geographical features. - Description of major islands or regions within the country. - Unique geographical aspects, like being part of a seismic belt or specific geological formations. - Climate characteristics, especially those influencing forestry.	Demographic Information - Current population estimate and growth rate. - Ethnic and cultural composition of the population. - Languages spoken and any lingua franca. - Distribution of population across different regions or provinces.	Biodiversity and Endemism - Description of biodiversity hotspots and ecoregions. - Details on the endemism and species richness. - Specific information on flora and fauna, including the number of species, level of endemism, and IUCN Red List status.	Threats to Biodiversity - Listing major threats such as logging, mining, over-exploitation, climate change, etc. - Impact of these threats on habitats and species.
Forest Types and Coverage Description of various forest types and their altitudinal ranges.	Socioeconomic Aspects Population distribution (urban vs. rural). Main economic activities, especially those related to natural resources. Importance of forestry to the country's economy. Statistics on forestry exports and sustainable harvesting rates.	Legal and Policy Framework Key legislation governing forestry and resource utilization. Roles and responsibilities of government bodies related to forestry. Recent policies or strategies aimed at sustainable forest management.	Sources Citing relevant governmental reports, census data, international assessments, etc.

☐ **Scope of the Standard:** The scope of the standard must be specific enough to determine which Indicators apply in which scenarios. For example, for **Small or Low Intensity** managed forests (**SLIMF**)²⁰ indicators may be developed that are especially tailored for those kinds of Management Units. However, a standard must make these distinctions clear in the Scope section. This includes types of forest, types of ownership, and types of products (e.g. detailing NTFPs [non-timber forest products]) – where applicable. Therefore, it should be determined whether the proposed Standard includes a SLIMF/non-SLIMF designation, or whether a different designation is applied. [SLIMF Eligibility Criteria \(STD-30-003\)](#) must be well-defined, and any national adaptations should be well-justified.²¹

While the addition of SLIMF indicators is not mandatory, check the relevant guidance to ensure that they are formulated correctly (see [FSC-STD-01-003](#)). Notably, management units may qualify as ‘small’ when

²⁰ See STD-01-003 for further reference

²¹ See also STD-01-003a for additional eligibility criteria.

they are **100 hectares** or smaller (section 1.2). Any deviation from this threshold needs to be accompanied by justification. When SLIMFs are included in a Standard, they should not be exempted from the requirements of the Standard.

Next, in the section of the Scope that relates to ‘Forest Products,’ “**Rough Wood**” should always be listed (denoting that timber sourced from a certified forest can be certified. In addition, **Non-timber forest products (NTFPs)** should also be mentioned in the Scope of a Standard, which indicates all non-timber products that can be sourced from forests and for which certification might be sought. If applicable for the Standard, these **NTFPs should be properly listed** according to **instructions in the current template** for FSS/RFSS:

“The SDG to note that when listing the NTFPs that apply, the types and wording of the NTFPs are aligned only with the raw (non-processed) NTFPs from the FSC Product Classification of the FSC-STD-40-004a, preferably with the Level 2 of such classification”

This means that all NTFPs for which certification is being sought should be listed as they are in STD-40-00a, preferably with the Item code (e.g. **W2, W3, W4**). Note: although the template instructions specify “Level 2 Classification”, the PSC has made clear that the “raw”, non-processed form of the NTFP should be listed (Level 1 Classification). [This Excel tool](#) can be used to correctly formulate the NTFPs for copying and pasting into the “Scope” section of an FSS.

In general, the use of SLIMF/NTFP indicators must be **correctly explained**, the normative elements should be **coherent**, and the **use of notes** (or other SDG-created elements – including advice notes or implementation notes) should be well-explained.

Criteria and Indicators

☐ **Indicators** should **NOT** include “**should**” or “**shall**” – there are only two exceptions to this rule: IGIs from Criterion 2.1, and IGI 5.1.3 (which have to include “shall”).

☐ **Adoption/Adaptation** processes are applied correctly. In FSS, SDGs are allowed to *adopt, adapt, drop, or add* indicators – as long as justification is provided (in all instances other than adoption of the IGIs). However, in IFSS, there should be no dropping or adding of any indicators.

☐ In **Principle 2**, Indicators related to the **International Labour Organization (ILO)**:

It’s expected that there should be at least no modification of these indicators, as they come from the ILO.

- Any adaptation of 2.1 needs strong justification;
- Likewise, dropping 2.4 is not acceptable (except in certain cases in IFSS)

It is also advisable to ask the SDG for any relevant national legislation regarding labor regulations (pertains to Indicator **2.1.1**), translated in English, in order to verify compliance with FSC procedures.

☐ **Principle 3: Relating to Criteria and Indicators regarding Indigenous Peoples’**

Rights: Proceed carefully if a Standard Developer argues for dropping Principle 3 (for example, owing to an “absence” of Indigenous Peoples in the country.) Justification must be provided. Additionally, check the Calibration Notes document and review previous decisions by the PSC in similar cases (e.g. Botswana, Ireland, Ghana, Solomon Islands, Uruguay, etc.) to ensure consistency.

In general, the FSS should reflect the use of 7 Criteria drawn from UNDRIP on the Identification of Indigenous Peoples in determining whether or not Principle 3 applies to their particular country.

☐ **Principle 5:** Related especially to indicators associated with timber harvesting levels (**Criterion 5.2**): Check if exceptions are provided in cases of calamities/natural disasters – if yes, does the Standard specify (in an adapted or added indicator) whether these losses will be accounted for/balanced out?

☐ In **Principle 6**, the **Conversion of Natural Forests to Plantations or other (non-forest) land uses**, (**Criteria 6.9, 6.10, and 6.11**):

This pertains especially to Standards that are aligned with Version 2-1 of the IGIs. This new version of the IGIs introduced changes to **Criteria 6.9 and 6.10**, and added **Criterion 6.11**. However, other standards that are being developed or revised according to older versions of the IGI (e.g. V2-0) should ideally (but are not obligated) include these criteria, indicators and glossary terms. That is because those new conversion requirements have already surpassed any conversion requirements existing in the currently valid standards (based on all previous versions of IGI or P&C), while future Standards will be required to incorporate these “new” requirements anyway.

There are a number of Advice notes pertaining to indicators relating to conversion, including:

- ADV-20-007-10 (Conversion of Plantation to Non-Forest)
- ADV-20-007-23 (Maximum Hectare Threshold for “Very Limited Portion”)

In case an SD incorporates these ‘new’ Criteria related to conversion in their FSS, they must also include the associated list of relevant terms and definitions in the Glossary of Terms. Specifically, these include:

Additionality	Restitution	Fibre
Conversion	Proportionate	
Direct involvement	Social harms	
Environmental harms	Ongoing social harms	
Indirect involvement	Priority social harms	
non-forest land-use	Small-scale smallholder	
Remedy		

testing – should be marked in indicator level, because its not

☐ **Hunting Indicators (IGIs ‘6.6.x’)**

These indicators are specifically related to wildlife protection, hunting, and the trade of bush meat. According to the Instructions for Standard Developers in the International Generic Indicators (STD-60-004), these indicators should be included in FSS (and IFSS) “in regions where hunting is threatening

species diversity”.²² While these regions are not specified in the standard itself, reviewers should use their best judgment, background research and SD justifications to determine whether the inclusion of these indicators is appropriate.

☐ **Conservation Areas Network (including Representative Sample Areas)** (primarily related to **Principle 6** and **Annex E**): The minimum shall be 10% of the Management Unit (**Indicator 6.5.5**).

☐ **High Conservation Values (HCV)** (related with **Principles 6 and 9**): Ensure the inclusion of the Annex related to HCV (Annex I in the template).

This must include information specifying:

- 1) Best Available Information,
- 2) Stakeholders
- 3) Identification of Threats, and
- 4) Measures for maintenance and enhancement of HCVs.
- 5) Information on monitoring of HCVs (e.g. detail, frequency),

For the development of IFSS, there is an expert who is engaged in the development of an HCV framework in consultation with the SDG – they are also available during the review process to help adjust and develop the HCV Framework.

☐ Ensure the inclusion of the term “**Intact Forest Landscape**”: If the term is omitted or relevant IGIs are dropped (from Criteria 9.2 and 9.3) , it is essential to double check whether there are no Intact Forest Landscapes in the country (in short, justification needs to be provided). If IFLs exist in a country - are the IFL indicators well incorporated? Is the threshold for their protection well-justified and acceptable?)

☐ **Principle 8 – Scale, Intensity, and Risk**

Scale, Intensity, and Risk – According to Guidelines Developed for Standard Developers Relating to Scale, Intensity, and Risk (SIR) GUI-60-002 V1-0 (EN), “The SIR approach provides an important opportunity for risk management based on the potential unacceptable negative impact of management activities.”²³

The “SIR Criteria” are:

1.7	5.4	6.5	9.3
2.3	5.5	7.1	9.4
4.3	6.1	7.2	10.9
4.4	6.2	7.6	
4.5	6.3	8.5	
5.1	6.4	9.1	

The SIR Indicators build on the rationale of SLIMF, which suggests that smaller Management Units are “unlikely to have potential unacceptable negative impacts on landscape level values including rare threatened and endangered species or representative sample areas.”²⁴ However, SIR Indicators seek to account for outsized impacts of Management Activities, even in small or low-intensity managed Management Units (for example, “if these MUs are located within the habitat for a rare species that

²² STD-60-004, pg. 44

²³ GUI-60-002, pg. 6, <https://fsc.org/sites/default/files/2019-08/SIR%20Guideline%201%20Feb%202016.pdf>

²⁴ Ibid.

depends on old growth forests, then timber cutting and road building could in fact have an unacceptable negative impact, regardless of the scale of the Organization of the intensity of its activities” [GUI-60-002].

With regards to **Criterion 8.5** (and specifically, **Indicator 8.5.1**) – double check that indicators relating to tracing and fibre-testing is adopted, and that the tracing rule is included for honey and/or venison (if applicable).

□ Principle 10

Pesticides Indicators

Within the framework of IGI V2-1, there are two sets of pesticides IGIs which shall be used as a starting point for the development of FSS indicators. This has to be based on respective instructions in the IGI document. The requirements of FSC Pesticides Policy [FSC-POL-30-001 V3-0](#) have to be taken into consideration. The first set includes the IGI from Criterion 10.7 (10.7.1-10.7.10). The second set is part of Annex J (10.7 11-10.7.27; specific IGIs for the use and risk management of highly hazardous pesticides). Normally, if pesticides are used in a respective country or region (for which the FSS is developed), all those pesticides IGI have to be adopted (or adapted with relevant justification). If pesticides are not used (i.e. prohibited by legislation), some IGI can be dropped.

Annexes –

The inclusion of certain Annexes is mandatory. These include²⁵:

- **Annex A (Principle 1)**, Provides that applicable **legislation and regulations** are provided for topics related to the implementation of the Standard.
- **Annex B (Principle 2)** Ensure that **training requirements** are included in National Standards and Interim National Standards which are proportionate to scale, intensity and risk and consistent with existing national and sub-national training requirements.
- **Annex D (Principle 6)** Provides a **Conservation Area Network** conceptual diagram, which Standard Developers shall use to inform the development of appropriate guidance at the national and regional level for the creation of Conservation Area Networks.
- **Annex E (Principle 7)** Covers **elements of the Management Plan**. Standard Developers shall ensure that the relevant elements of this Annex are included in the requirements for the content of management plans, subject to scale, intensity and risk and consistent with national and regional management planning frameworks.
- **Annex G (Principle 8)** Covers the content of the **Monitoring Plans**.
- **Annex H (Principle 9)** Relates to **Intact Forest Landscapes**.
- **Annex I (Principle 9)**: Presentation of Strategies for maintaining **High Conservation Values**.

The instructions for Standard Developers in the IGIs state that SDGs should “consider the following strategies [listed in Annex I of the IGIs] to inform the development of indicators to maintain High Conservation Values. In general, this means that SDs are free to structure the information required by this Annex in the manner they deem most appropriate, as long as it covers the following:

- Interpretations of the six HCV categories;
- Methodologies to support the identification, protection, and monitoring of HCVs, and

²⁵ See STD-60-004 Section E.4 (pg. 9)

- Best Available Information (BAI) for identifying, protecting, and monitoring HCVs.

Advice for Standard Developers in developing an HCV Strategy, and this Annex, are provided by [GUI-60-009](#) (Guidelines), and [GUI-60-009a](#) (a Template for National HCV Frameworks). Once again, the use of the Template is NOT required, but can be used for guidance in structuring information.

Note: This Annex should be deleted **only if** the contents of this Annex are adequately captured by the Indicators developed under Principle 9.

- **Annex J (Principle 10):** International Generic Indicators for the use of highly hazardous pesticides

FSS may (but are not required to) include

- **Annex C (Principle 5):** Provides additional Requirements for Ecosystem Services; Was transferred to <[FSC-PRO-30-006](#) Ecosystem Services Procedure: Impact Demonstration and Market Tools.>
- **Annex F (Principle 7)** Conceptual framework for planning and monitoring; Standard Developers may use this diagram to inform the periodicity for revision of the various management planning and monitoring documents.

Important: Just because an Annex is not listed as mandatory in FSC-STD-60-004 does not necessarily mean that it is not required. In cases where they don't include an Annex (e.g. Annex F), it has to cover to the same level of detail (and it is rare that they would be able to do this without including the associated Annex). Compare the Annexes in the template to ensure that no areas or indicators are weakened in the formulation of the Annex in the proposed standard. Also, the formulation of the Annex or condition provided in the annexes needs to be linked to Criteria for reference.

Figure 3. Assessment Details by Criterion and Indicator

The table below compiles information both from the IGLs (especially Instructions for Standard Developers), Advice Notes and Guidance Notes, as well as internal PSU collaboration. This table is a **living document** that can be added on to periodically.

Yellow = a “problematic IGI”

Indicators			
Criterion	Indicator	What to Look For	Why
1.1	1.1.1	Are <i>customary rights</i> governing access and use identified and used to write additional indicators to ensure these rights to carry out these activities are within the scope of the certificate are documented?	This comes from the Instructions for Standard Developers under Principle 1, on page 12 of the IGLs
1.1	1.1.2	Double check if this IGI has been dropped.	This IGI is sometimes considered redundant with 1.1.1. The reasoning is often that only legally competent authorities can provide unchallenged legal registration. Approval conditions from PSC for this indicator often request a satisfactory adaptation or, in the case of NFSS, a proper and sound justification for the dropping of an IGI when redundancy is claimed. If there is certainty that these IGI are redundant within the scope of the standard, • elaborate a proper and sound explanation on the redundancy of the IGI (e.g. explain in detail how the compliance with 1.1.1 is equivalent to the compliance with 1.1.2) and • consider modifying/adapting or merging the redundant IGLs while keeping the resultant indicator(s) SMART and aligned with the scope of their criteria (example: IGI 1.1.2 is dropped and the phrase “legally competent authority” added to 1.1.1).
1.2	1.2.1	Are appropriate process recognizing and granting <i>customary rights</i> related to use and access <u>identified and documented</u> ? Are <i>customary tenures</i> to manage and use resources exist at the national level incorporated into indicators?	This comes from the Instructions for Standard Developers under Principle 1, on page 12 of the IGLs This IGI is sometimes considered redundant with 1.2.2. The reasoning is often that only legally competent authorities can provide unchallenged legal registration. Approval conditions from PSC for this indicator often request a satisfactory adaptation or, in the case of NFSS, a proper and sound justification for the dropping of an IGI when redundancy is claimed. Proposed Strategy: If there is certainty that these IGI are redundant within the scope of the standard,

			• elaborate a proper and sound explanation on the redundancy of the IGI (e.g. explain in detail how the compliance with 1.1.1 is equivalent to the compliance with 1.1.2) and • consider modifying/adapting or merging the redundant IGIs while keeping the resultant indicator(s) SMART and aligned with the scope of their criteria (example: IGI 1.1.2 is dropped and the phrase “legally competent authority” added to 1.1.1).
1.2	1.2.2	Double check if this indicator has been dropped.	This IGI is sometimes considered redundant with 1.2.1. The reasoning is often that only legally competent authorities can provide unchallenged legal registration. Approval conditions from PSC for this indicator often request a satisfactory adaptation or, in the case of NFSS, a proper and sound justification for the dropping of an IGI when redundancy is claimed. Proposed Strategy If there is certainty that these IGI are redundant within the scope of the standard, • elaborate a proper and sound explanation on the redundancy of the IGI (e.g. explain in detail how the compliance with 1.1.1 is equivalent to the compliance with 1.1.2) and • consider modifying/adapting or merging the redundant IGIs while keeping the resultant indicator(s) SMART and aligned with the scope of their criteria (example: IGI 1.1.2 is dropped and the phrase “legally competent authority” added to 1.1.1).
1.6	1.6.1	Does the Indicator state that a “dispute resolution process” is in not only “in place,” but is also <i>developed</i> in a proactive and culturally appropriate way?	A “culturally appropriate” dispute resolution is particularly important in the case of the inclusion of Principle 3 and Principle 4
1.6	1.6.4	Double check if the indicator has been dropped.	This IGI is sometimes considered redundant with 4.6.4 (and vice versa). The reasoning is often that the wording is similar. Approval conditions from PSC for this indicator often request a satisfactory adaptation or, in the case of NFSS, a proper and sound justification for the dropping of an IGI when redundancy is claimed. Proposed Strategy If there is certainty that these IGI are redundant within the scope of the standard, • elaborate a proper and sound explanation on the redundancy of the IGI (e.g. explain in detail how the compliance with 1.1.1 is equivalent to the compliance with 1.1.2) and • consider modifying/adapting or merging the redundant IGIs while keeping the resultant indicator(s) SMART and aligned with the scope of their criteria (example: IGI 1.1.2 is dropped and the phrase “legally competent authority” added to 1.1.1).

			The dropping of IGI 4.6.4 might be acceptable if adapted IGI 1.6.4 includes local communities in its scope.
1.7	All	Is a Scale Intensity and Risk (SIR) Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this an Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
1.7	1.7.4	If anti-corruption laws and regulations are ineffective/not existent in the country, do the Standard Developers include reference to other kinds of anti-corruption	This comes from the Instructions for Standard Developers under Principle 1, on page 15 of the IGIs
2.1	all, but especially in 2.1.1	Are any indicators (or the Criterion itself) dropped?	Any indicators related to this Criterion need very strong justification – any dropping or modifications of these indicators need to be reviewed carefully. See also section below on Labor Regulations, Living Wage, and Minimum Wage under “Special Topics” for further information.
2.1	2.1.1 (including 2.1.1.1, 2.1.1.2, 2.1.1.3, 2.1.1.4)	See above	An FSC report on generic criteria and indicators based on ILO Core Conventions Principles lists examples of Means of Verification for the indicators of this Criterion that Standard Developers can provide: namely, Documents: Pay records; Records of labour inspectorate; Employer Records (Age Register), identity documents such as copies of birth certificates or national ID cards; Risk Assessment & Hazardous Substance; Assessment; Employment Policy/ Procedures; Local/ national law; Findings of employment surveys; School records and social workers; Local labour office Interviews: Sample of workers; Representatives of workers and unions; School authorities and social workers; Representatives of employer Observations
2.1	2.1.2 (2.1.2.1 and 2.1.2.2)	See above	An FSC report on generic criteria and indicators based on ILO Core Conventions Principles lists examples of Means of Verification for the indicators of this Criterion that Standard Developers can provide: namely, Documents: Pay records; Records of labour inspectorate; Employment contracts, Statutory deductions (Tax, social security); national/industry standards (for comparison); Dispute and grievance records; Records of licensed recruitment agencies Interviews: Sample of workers; Representatives of workers and unions; Social workers and NGOs; Supervisors; Representatives of employer Observations Visit to camping/housing sites
2.1	2.1.3 (2.1.3.1)	See above	An FSC report on generic criteria and indicators based on ILO Core Conventions Principles lists examples of Means of Verification for the indicators of this Criterion that Standard Developers can provide: namely,

			Documents: Pay records; Records of labour inspectorate; Adverts, Job applications records; Grievances/complaints register; Job evaluation (appraisals); Affirmative action program (Should be defined); Policies and procedures; Employment demographic/gender ration in job types; Discriminatory reports/social responsibility reports Interviews: Sample of workers; Representatives of employer; Representatives of workers and union Observations Welfare facilities for men and women
2.1	2.1.4 (2.1.4.1-2.1.4.4)	See above	An FSC report on generic criteria and indicators based on ILO Core Conventions Principles lists examples of Means of Verification for the indicators of this Criterion that Standard Developers can provide: namely, Documents: Organizational policies; Complaints register; Collective Agreements; Minutes of bilateral meetings; Minister of Labour/Industrial Relations reports; Court reports/awards Interviews: Workers and trade union representatives; Human resource personnel; Representatives of Employer Observations
2.3		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this an Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
2.4	All	Are any indicators (or the Criterion itself) dropped?	This cannot be dropped (a very limited exception applies for IFSS)
2.4	2.4.2 and 2.4.3	Standard Developers are supposed to identify three things – forest industry standards, other kinds of forest industry wage agreements (if applicable), and living wage benchmarks. Then, they have to identify which of these are higher than the legal minimum wage, and by how much.	This comes from the Instructions for Standard Developers under Principle 2, on page 23 of the IGIs
2.6	2.6.1	Have Standard Developers developed indicators to ensure that culturally appropriate measures are used to define and shape dispute resolution processes?	This comes from the Instructions for Standard Developers on page 23 of the IGIs
3.1-3.6		Are any of the Criteria (or the Principle itself) dropped?	If Principle 3 is included in the Standard, it is important that all Criteria are adopted as well – If an SDG is seeking to drop P3, strong justification for the lack of presence of Indigenous Peoples in the country needs to be provided, and this will be placed under strong scrutiny. In addition, see page 26 of the IGIs (Instructions for Standard Developers) for further considerations

4.1-4.8	All	Local communities that qualify as “traditional communities” are identified	This understanding is per Motion 40a/2021 (Review the applicability of Free, Prior, and Informed Consent [FPIC] in Principle 4); it is also referenced in the Instructions for Standard Developers under Criterion 4.1 on page 31 of the IGIs
4.1	4.1.1	Does the understanding of “local communities” in this indicator include both those communities that neighbor the Management Unit as well as those that may be a bit more distant that could experience negative impacts as a result of management activities?	This is included in the Instructions for Standard Developers in the IGIs on page 31
4.1	4.1.2	The mechanisms to address disputes with local communities should match up with the requirements of Criterion 1.6 (if the disputes are related to legal tenure) and Criterion 4.6 (if they are related to the impacts of management activities)	This is included in the Instructions for Standard Developers for Criterion 4.1 in the IGIs on page 31
4.2	4.2.5	Standard Developers have to ensure that the term “good faith” is used here as it is in the ILO Conventions and is an auditable element	This is included in the Instructions for Standard Developers for Criterion 4.2 in the IGIs on page 31
4.3		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this as a Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
4.4		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this as a Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
4.5	All	Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this as a Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
4.5	4.5.1	This indicator (or indicators added to the Standard) need to make clear the degree that the Organization is responsible for contributing to mitigating the resulting negative social and economic impacts on affected communities	This is touched on in the Instructions for Standard Developers for Criterion 4.5 on page 33 of the IGIs
4.6	4.6.4	Double check if this indicator has been dropped or not.	The dropping of IGI 4.6.4 might be acceptable if adapted IGI 1.6.4 includes local communities in its scope. Proposed Strategy: If there is certainty that these IGI are redundant within the scope of the standard, • elaborate a proper and sound explanation on the redundancy of the IGI (e.g. explain in detail how the compliance with 1.1.1 is equivalent to the compliance with 1.1.2) and • consider modifying/adapting or merging the redundant IGIs while keeping the resultant indicator(s) SMART and aligned with the scope of their criteria (example: IGI 1.1.2 is dropped and the phrase “legally competent authority” added to 1.1.1). The dropping of IGI 4.6.4 might be acceptable if adapted IGI 1.6.4 includes local communities in its scope.

4.8	4.8.1 and 4.8.2	Has this indicator been adapted or dropped?	Sometimes this indicator is not considered applicable, considering national/regional circumstances. Approval conditions for this Criterion and respective IGLs often request: a satisfactory adaptation or a proper and sound justification for the dropping of the Criteria/IGLs Proposed Strategy: • If there is certainty that traditional knowledge is not applicable within the scope of the standard, • elaborate a proper and sound explanation on the inapplicability of the IGI (e.g. the scope of the standard covers commercial exotic plantations and no traditional knowledge exists for their management; or in some countries, traditional knowledge might exist but it could be regarded as public property by legislation; therefore, nobody could charge a fee for sharing such knowledge); • demonstrate that the IGLs are not contributing to the objectives of Criteria and standard in general and • drop the IGI for which there is a proper and sound justification as mentioned above.
5.1		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this an Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
5.2	5.2.1	Is Best Available Information Specified (examples: up-to-date growth and yield information? Up-to-date inventory data? Etc.)	It's important to ensure that timber harvesting targets are adjusted in case of natural disasters – especially where little or no prior analysis has to be completed and/or where data is weak or does not exist; therefore this has to be accounted for in the formulation of the indicators. For further reference, see Instructions for Standard Developers for Criterion 5.2 on page 36 of the International Generic Indicators
5.2	5.2.2	Check if exceptions are provided in cases of calamities/natural disasters – if yes, does the Standard specify (in an adapted or added indicator) whether these losses will be accounted for/balanced out?	See above
5.2	5.2.3	Check if exceptions are provided in cases of calamities/natural disasters – e.g. windthrow, fire, pest epidemics, etc. - if yes, it is possible for a <i>temporary and non-routine annual harvest rate in excess of allowable cut</i> levels, but the Standard should specify (in an adapted or added indicator) whether these losses will be accounted for/balanced out?	
5.2	5.2.4	Is Best Available Information Specified (examples: up-to-date growth and yield information? Up-to-date inventory data? Etc.)	see Instructions for Standard Developers for Criterion 5.2 on page 36 of the International Generic Indicators
5.3	5.3.1 and 5.3.2	Are these IGLs adapted or dropped?	Many SDs have indicated that the Criterion and its IGLs were two difficult to implement.

			Proposed Strategy: IGI 5.3.1 and 5.3.2 can be dropped if not applicable in the context of the geographic area covered by the scope of the standard.
5.4		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this a Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
5.5		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this a Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
6.1	All	- Is a SIR Indicator Included? - Is Best Available Information defined for the indicators where it is required?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this a Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
6.2		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this a Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
6.3		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this a Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
6.4		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this a Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
6.5	All	Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this a Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
6.5	6.5.5	The Representative Sample area should be 10% of the Management Unit at a minimum	Common issues with this IGI: The IGI, if adopted, is difficult to implement for some certificate holders, especially for smallholders. The minimum 10% of conservation areas network (CAN) might become the aim in itself, which contradicts the requirements of the Conceptual Diagram (Annex D of FSC-STD-60-004), which sets 10% as the minimum and encourages higher percentages. As a rule, PSC does not approve national standards which do not set aside at least 10% of the MU as CAN Following the request of the PSC in January 18, PSU has conducted a study that has provided further clarifications on the difficulties associated with development and implementation of indicators under Criterion 6.5 and proposed relevant solutions. A respective pilot study has also been carried out by New Approaches (At present Community and Family Forests) in China. The findings of that pilot project have been taken into consideration by the above-mentioned study. The information about outcomes of the study will be shared by PSU with the Forest Management Community and other interested parties in January, 2024.
6.6	6.6.x	In regions where hunting is threatening species diversity, these indicators should be included in FSS (and IFSS).	See IGIs, pg. 44
6.9	All	Is the Standard Version 2-1 or above? If yes , the changes to the IGIs in this Criterion should be adopted. If	

		no (for example, standards being revised into V-2-0 of the IGIs), the adoption of these indicator changes is <i>not mandatory</i> , but is highly preferable	
6.10	All	Is the Standard Version 2-1 or above? If yes , the changes to the IGIs in this Criterion should be adopted. If no (for example, standards being revised into V-2-0 of the IGIs), the adoption of these indicator changes is <i>not mandatory</i> , but is highly preferable	- FSC-ADV-20-007-10 (Conversion of Plantation to Non-Forest) - FSC-ADV-20-007-23 (Maximum Hectare Threshold for “Very Limited Portion”)
6.11	All	Is the Standard Version 2-1 or above? If yes , the changes to the IGIs in this Criterion should be adopted. If no (for example, standards being revised into V-2-0 of the IGIs), the adoption of these indicator changes is <i>not mandatory</i> , but is highly preferable	
7.1		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this an Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
7.2		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this an Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
7.6		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this an Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
8.5		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this an Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
8.5	8.5.1	Indicators on tracing and fibre-testing is adopted, and that tracing rule is included for honey and/or venison	It is not really acceptable that 8.5.1 be dropped or weakened in any way (internal guidelines)
9.1		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this an Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
9.3		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this an Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
9.4		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this an Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
10.3	10.3.4	If the phrase “in cooperation with separate regulatory bodies where these exist” is dropped, it needs to be justified.	In line with recent PSC decisions
10.9		Is a SIR Indicator Included?	The SIR Guidelines (FSC-GUI-60-002) note this an Criterion that SDGs should specifically account for scale intensity and risk. See GUI-60-002 pg. 14-45 for greater detail on how this should be done
Annexes			

Annex A	Relates to Principle 1; Key questions to answer: - Are all obligatory codes of practice* and legal* and customary rights* at the national and, where applicable, sub-national level listed? - In Section 3.4, are national laws and regulations regarding workers' health and safety that meet or exceed certain ILO requirements exist? See also: - Instructions for Standard Developers under Principle 1, on page 13 of the IGIs; see also page 16 for a detailed "Minimum List of Applicable Laws, Regulations, and Nationally-ratified International Treaties, Conventions, and Agreements" - Instructions for Standard Developers under Principle 2 on page 22 of the IGIs	
Annex B	- Standard Developers have to ensure a certain list of training requirements (listed on page 25 of the IGIs) are added to an Annex B, adapted to the scale, intensity, and risk - The list of training requirements and further instructions are located in the Instructions for Standard Developers on page 25	
Annex D	Relates to Principle 6 - Standard Developers must use the conceptual diagram to inform the creation of the Conservation Area Network	
Annex E	Relates to Principle 7 - The minimum Representative Sample Area should be 10% of the Management Unit	
Annex G	Relates to Principle 8 - Standard Developers shall ensure that the relevant elements of this Annex are included in the requirements for the content of Monitoring Plans, consistent with existing national and sub-national monitoring approaches and subject to scale intensity and risk.	
Annex H	Relates to Principle 9 - For countries with Intact Forest Landscapes Standards Developers shall use the following instructions for establishing: Page 11 of 107 International Generic Indicators FSC-STD-60-004 V2-1 EN Annex Title Application for Standard Developers The threshold for vast majority of Intact Forest Landscapes as core areas; and Indicators for assessing and protecting Intact Forest Landscapes.	
HCV Annex (<i>Annex I in Template</i>)	Relates to Principle 9; This template must be used in the creation of an HCV framework. Must include information on: Best Available Information, Stakeholders, Identification of Threats, Measures for Maintenance and Enhancement of HCVs; Information on Monitoring of HCVs	
Annex J (relates to Principle 10) In countries where highly hazardous pesticides are used or likely to be used, Standard Developers shall refer to this Annex to develop national indicators for the use and risk management of highly hazardous pesticides		
Criterion	Indicator	Basis of Assessment
10.7	10.7.12	Standard Developers shall determine, using Best Available Information*, whether critical population density* is an appropriate measure to determine intervention threshold* for a particular pest*
10.7	10.7.13	Standard Developers shall consider the need to specify research requirements
10.7	10.7.14	Standard Developers shall consider the need to specify essential risk mitigation measures for a particular highly hazardous pesticide*, and shall adapt Indicator 10.7.14 and/or add indicators accordingly
10.7	10.7.15	Standard Developers shall identify any gaps between the appropriate personal protective equipment specified in national laws and regulations or product labels and the personal protective equipment specified in FSC-POL-30-001b Personal Protective Equipment . Standard Developers shall adapt indicator 10.7.15 based on this gap analysis
10.7	10.7.16	Standard Developers shall consider the need to specify the characteristics of any pesticide buffer zone* or exclusion zone* for a particular highly hazardous pesticide*, and if so, shall adapt the

		relevant indicator(s) accordingly with reference to the chemical pesticides* label instructions, safety data sheets or regulations as appropriate. When a pesticide buffer zone* and/or exclusion zone* is not appropriate for a particular highly hazardous pesticide*, Standard Developers may drop the relevant indicator(s)
10.7	10.7.19	Standard developers shall consider the need for training requirements for a particular highly hazardous pesticide*, and shall adapt indicators accordingly
10.7	10.7.20, 10.7.21 and 10.7.22	Standard developers shall consider the need for monitoring requirements for a particular highly hazardous pesticide*, and shall adapt indicators accordingly
10.7	10.7.22 and 10.7.26	Standard Developers shall consider Indicators 10.7.22 and 10.7.26 only for highly hazardous pesticides* listed on the basis of their environmental toxicity (hazard criteria 7 and 8).
<i>Glossary of Terms</i>		
If Criteria 6.9, 6.10, and 6.11 are adopted...	Additionality; Conversion; Direct involvement; Environmental harms; Indirect involvement; non-forest land-use; Ongoing social harms; Priority social harms; Proportionate; Remedy; Restitution; Small-scale smallholder; Social harms.	

Regional Forest Stewardship Standards (RFSS)

The Regional Forest Stewardship Standards (RFSS) represent a significant development in the inclusion of smallholders in the Forest Stewardship Council (FSC) certification system. This initiative, originating in the Asia Pacific region (specifically from India, Indonesia, Thailand, and Vietnam) in 2019, focuses on integrating family-owned plantations, including those cultivating plants or rubber, into the FSC framework.

A key challenge in this process has been addressing the limited capacities of smallholders, particularly in terms of literacy, technical expertise, and economic constraints, such as insufficient funding for the certification process. To overcome these hurdles, several strategies have been proposed. These include simplifying the standard as much as possible, either by reducing the number of International Generic Indicators (IGIs) or using very simple language. Additionally, there is an emphasis on obtaining support from other NGOs to assist smallholder certificate-holders.

A pivotal aspect of this initiative is the development of regional standards. However, it's important to note that these regional standards cannot be implemented unless they are adapted at the national level. Unlike other Forest Stewardship Standards, which involve a chamber balance of economic, social, and ecological chambers, the regional standards specifically highlight the conditions that smallholders in each respective country need to adopt.

The standard has undergone all necessary approval procedures, including a conditional approval by the Policy and Standards Committee (PSC) for pilot testing²⁶. Concerning the adaptation of these regional standards to national standards, the SDGs present in each country must endorse the regional standards. They have the authority to decide which annexes from the main FSC Standards should be included in this adaptation.

The PSU (Policy and Standards Unit) is authorized to approve the regional standard once it has been endorsed by the country's SDG. However, SDGs are restricted from altering indicators unless a request is submitted to the PSC for a decision.

The RFSS differs in various aspects from the standard templates:

- The scope is defined as less than 20 hectares, with no specific justification required for this figure, except to ensure the inclusion of as many smallholders as possible.
- Some criteria have been dropped due to their lack of applicability to individual smallholders.
- For quality assurance, a comparison of the RFSS with the already approved country standard is conducted within the region.

²⁶ As of December 2023

Special Topics Relevant to Reviews

Identification of and Consultation with Indigenous Peoples

The identification of Indigenous Peoples is a crucial issue relevant to carrying out reviews of FSS. Principle 3 of the FSC Principles and Criteria is focused specifically on the rights of Indigenous Peoples. Consideration for Indigenous Peoples are related to, but distinct from considerations for local communities, which is the focus of Principle 4.

Principle 3 of the FSC Principles and Criteria: “The Organisation shall identify and uphold Indigenous Peoples’ legal and customary rights of ownership, use and management of land, territories and resources affected by management activities.”

In the December 2023 PSC Meeting, PSU presented the current challenges presented by the identification of Indigenous Peoples in standards that have come up for a decision in recent years, such as Ghana or Ireland. The PSC determined that no FSC entities – including FSC Board and/or the Permanent Indigenous Peoples Committee (PIPC), PSU and PSC - should be in a position to make political determinations related to the presence of Indigenous Peoples in a country. This is an especially delicate matter because of the lack of recognition of Indigenous Peoples in certain countries, or because designation of a community as “indigenous” could create conflict between communities.

Currently, an expert evaluator has been brought in in particular cases to determine whether or not Indigenous Peoples are present – however, going forward, PSU is exploring ways to make this process more robust. Options to be potentially explored include the creation of a map (perhaps developed by the FSC Indigenous Foundation) showing where Indigenous Peoples are located globally, or the hiring of an expert to develop guidelines (e.g. a decision-tree) to determine whether or not Indigenous Peoples are present. In either case, a robust system for internal peer review should be established.

Currently, there are two key guidelines provided by FSC that are related to Consultation of Indigenous Peoples: Guidelines for **Stakeholder Involvement** and **Free, Prior and Informed Consent** are the two main resources available to PSU (and to SDGs) to inform best practices for the consultation and participation of Indigenous Peoples in the development of forestry standards .

The **Guidance for Stakeholder Involvement (FSC-GUI-30-011)** details best practices and approaches in undertaking stakeholder engagement for a variety of purposes and applications in the FSC certification scheme. In particular, it “aims to avoid common pitfalls and guide FSC certificate holders and other stakeholders toward successful mutual engagement by following a straightforward three-step approach: **mapping** stakeholders, and **planning and implementing** measures for stakeholder involvement.

Section 3.3. of GUI-30-011 focuses specifically on the identification of Local Communities and Indigenous Peoples. In particular, it:

- Emphasizes the **identification of Indigenous Peoples** as a crucial part of stakeholder mapping, identifying **NGOs or other civil society organizations** as important sources for
- Notes that the identification of Indigenous Peoples **require special attention** due to risks they face, including loss of identity, culture, traditional lands, and natural resource-based livelihoods;

- Identifies **unique challenges** that might impact stakeholder engagement with Indigenous Peoples, including lack of access to technology, geographic barriers, linguistic barriers, etc.
- Specifies that certificate holders are expected to adhere to the guidelines of **Free, Prior, and Informed Consent (FPIC)** when “engaging Indigenous Peoples as rights holders”

Similarly, the FPIC Guidelines (FSC-GUI-30-003) offer very detailed guidelines and best practices for carrying out an “FPIC Process.”

The 7 steps of the FPIC Process include:

- 1) Identifying the rights holder and their rights,*
- 2) Preparing for further engagement and agreeing on scope*
- 3) Participatory mapping and assessments,*
- 4) Informing affected rights holders*
- 5) Affected rights holders deliberate and decided*
- 6) Verification and formalization of the FPIC Agreement*
- 7) Implementation and Monitoring of FPIC Agreement.*

Some key highlights of the FPIC Guidelines include:

- **Respecting Human Rights:** Emphasizing international human rights standards, particularly the rights to self-determination and control over land and resources.
- **FPIC Specific Elements:** Detailed explanation of the four elements of FPIC - free, prior, informed, and consent - ensuring decision-making processes are voluntary, well-informed, and timely.
- **Culturally Appropriate Engagement:** Guidelines on how to engage with Indigenous Peoples in a manner that respects their cultural practices and decision-making processes.
- **Iterative Decision-Making:** Recognizing the dynamic nature of consent, where Indigenous Peoples retain the right to modify, withhold, or withdraw consent.
- **Documentation and Verification:** Emphasizing the importance of documenting the FPIC process and outcomes for accountability and verification purposes.

In both cases, the guidance is uniquely targeted towards certification bodies. For example, the FPIC Guidelines note that “ultimately, the CB [Certification Body] has the responsibility to verify that the affected rights holder has made a decision under the conditions of FPIC”

There are a few notable gaps in these two documents, which may be ground for further exploration and discussion in the creation of guidelines. These include:

- **Inclusivity in Consultation Processes:** Guidelines could further emphasize the inclusion of all segments of Indigenous communities, ensuring that vulnerable or marginalized groups are adequately represented and heard.
- **Language and Communication Barriers:** More detailed strategies could be outlined to overcome language and communication barriers, ensuring that information is accessible in the native languages of Indigenous Peoples.

- **Long-Term Engagement:** The guidelines might benefit from a stronger focus on long-term engagement strategies, rather than just consultation for specific projects. This would foster ongoing relationships and trust.
- **Addressing Power Imbalances:** The guidelines could provide more robust strategies to address power imbalances between forestry stakeholders and Indigenous communities to ensure equitable negotiation processes.
- **Impact Assessment:** Greater emphasis could be placed on impact assessments, both prior to and following the implementation of forest standards, to monitor and evaluate the effects on Indigenous communities.

Labor Regulations, Living Wage, and Minimum Wage

In 2016, a report was prepared by Arche Advisors to provide additional clarification on the topic of Guidance for Living Wage Auditor. The purpose of the Guidance was for certification bodies to aid the verification of the payment of living wages where country-specific estimates have been prepared. Therefore, this information is of high value for the Country Requirements program in general, and for the adaptation of country Standards.

The definition of a living wage, according to the Living Wage Coalition, is:

'Remuneration received from a standard work week by a worker in a particular place sufficient to afford a decent standard of living for the worker and her or his family. Elements of a decent standard of living include food, water, housing, education, health care, transport, clothing, and other essential needs including provision for unexpected events.'

In the FSC normative framework, a living wage is defined as 'The level of wages sufficient to meet the basic living needs of an average-sized family in a particular economy', and indicators state that remuneration must 'Meet industry standard or living wages, *whatever is higher*'.

The guidance document ([GUI-30-007](#)) – provides a handful of definitions and a common methodology across multiple standards systems, as well as specific tips to auditors conducting reviews related to payment verification and wage analysis. Finally, the Guidance note also provides a Table in the Annex showing the Maximum percentage allowed for in-kind benefits as a partial payment of wages.

Living wage benchmarks by country are determined using the Anker Methodology, and are compiled by the [Global Living Wage Coalition](#). This Living Wage report should provide the following information:

- Gross living wage estimate
- Net living wage estimate
- Discussion of common cash allowances and common in-kind benefits (meals, housing, transport) and their estimates
- Discussion of common housing conditions for workers.

These sources of information are used by auditors for reference during wage verification activities – they are specific to the region for which they were conducted, and not specific to any commodity or product.

Please note that **living wage** and **minimum wage** are not synonymous – rather, the legal minimum wage may be below a living wage. This is important for adaptations of indicators regarding remuneration, specifically adaptations sought along the lines of equating the 'forest industry standard' with 'minimum wage'.

Intact Forest Landscapes

The Guidance Note FSC-GUI-030-010 provides advice on the designation of Intact Forest Landscapes. According to the Guidance Note, IFLs are present in:

Angola, Argentina, Australia, Belize, Bhutan, Bolivia, Brazil, Brunei, Cambodia, Cameroon, Canada, Central African Republic, Chile, China, Colombia, Congo DRC, Costa Rica, Cote d'Ivoire, Dominican Rep, Ecuador, Equatorial Guinea, Ethiopia, Finland, French Guiana, Gabon, Georgia, Guatemala, Guyana, Honduras, India, Indonesia, Japan, Kazakhstan, Laos, Liberia, Madagascar, Malaysia, Mexico, Mongolia, Myanmar, New Zealand, Nicaragua, Nigeria, Norway, Panama, Papua N Guinea, Paraguay, Peru, Philippines, Repl. Congo, Russia, Solomon Islands, Suriname, Sweden, Tanzania, Thailand, Uganda, United States, Venezuela and Vietnam.

Annex 1: Additional Resources for Reviews

[A Guide on Conducting FSS Reviews](#) by Gordian Fanzo (a previous PSU staff member) on how NFSS are assessed. While many of the principles of this guide to reviews may still be relevant, it is possible that it is somewhat outdated and/or replaced by more up-to-date information.

[A Guide to PSU Staff Tasks by Stage](#) in FSS Review Process by Gordian Fanzo (A previous PSU staff member), outlining what kinds of steps need to be taken at each stage of the FSS Review process by staff. While many of the key elements of this document may still be true today, it may have been replaced by new processes/rules in the intervening time since its publication.

A document summarizing '[Explanatory Notes and Rationales](#)' for the FSC Principles and Criteria gives a detailed breakdown of the intention behind the design and scope of each Indicator and Criteria. This list is **internal**, and not to be shared, but provides similar information as to what is available in the Instructions for Standard developers. This information may be particularly useful to assess whether or not a suggested adaptation of an indicator fits with the intended spirit of the IGI/Criterion.

Similar to above, a document summarizing the '[Desired Outcome for Each Criterion](#)' provides a 1-2 sentence summary of the key goals/aims of the Principles and Criteria (Version 5), for reference when assessing the appropriateness of adaptations (for example).

A [guide on PSC Decisions](#) lists various issues – both broad level and indicator-specific – and provides the PSC's approach to such issues since 2018. The document was last updated in 2023, and it is envisioned that this document should be updated regularly.

Annex 2: A Glossary of Language Reviews

Compliance: Used only to refer to alignment/ 'conformance' with legal obligations.

Conformance: Used only to refer to alignment with FSC Documents.

Annex 3: Achim's Checklist for Reviewing FSS:

This checklist has been adapted from Achim's internal list for what to check for when reviewing a FSS.

1. Scope & Use of Indicators:

- **Scope Formulation:** Is the scope clearly defined? Check for clarity and specificity in the formulation.
- **SLIMF In/Out (SLIMF Eligibility):** Verify if SLIMF is appropriately included or excluded based on the SLIMF eligibility criteria. Check if national adaption is justified.
- **NTFP Listing:** Ensure that Non-Timber Forest Products (NTFPs) are correctly listed if applicable.
- **SLIMF/NTFP Indicators:** Verify if the use of SLIMF and NTFP indicators is correctly explained.

2. List of Normative Elements:

- **Coherence:** Check if the list of normative elements is coherent and logically structured.

3. Use of Notes or SDG-Created Elements:

- **Explanation:** Verify if the use of notes or other SDG-created elements (e.g., 'advice', 'implementation note', etc.) is well-explained and deemed acceptable.

4. Correct Application of Adopting/Adapting Concept:

- **Adopting/Adapting:** Ensure that the concept of adopting/adapting is correctly applied. No dropping or adding indicators in IFSS.

5. Critical Criteria/Indicators:

- **2.1 (ILO):** Check if any adaptation to 2.1 has strong justification.
- **2.4:** Verify if dropping is exceptionally okay in IFSS.
- **P3 Applicability:** Ensure that all 7 criteria are used if P3 is applicable.
- **5.2 Exceptions:** Check if exceptions are provided for calamities and if they are required to be balanced out.
- **6.5.5 (10% Rule):** Ensure that the 10% rule is not violated.
- **8.5.1 (Tracing and Fibre-Testing):** Confirm if tracing and fibre-testing are adopted.
- **8.5 (Tracing Rule):** Verify if the tracing rule is included for honey/venison (if applicable).
- **9.x (IFL Indicators):** Check if IFL indicators are well incorporated, justified, and acceptable threshold applied.

6. Other Issues:

- **Group Certification:** Ensure no group certification content is present in the FSS, except in notes as an explanation (e.g., for 6.5.5). This is because each Management Unit is required to meet the requirements individually – so notes which contain content such as “ requirements can be met at

the group level” are not acceptable (as this would weaken the force of the indicator requirement).²⁷

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- **Annexes Completeness:** Confirm if annexes, especially the HCV Framework, are complete.
- **Layout & Formatting:** Conduct a quick check for layout, formatting, look, and feel issues (weird page breaks, inconsistent layout, numbering system, etc).

7. SLIMF Inclusions:

- **Exceptions:** Check if there are no exceptions from requirements when SLIMF is included.

8. Overall Compliance with P&C Preamble:

- **Compliance:** Ensure that all certified Management Units comply with all Principles and Criteria and the Preamble.

²⁷ Group Certifications are covered by a different [FSC Standard -FSC-30-005](#). For the purposes of FSS development, it is important to ensure that a FSS does not conflict with/create different requirements than a group standard.

Annex 4: Additional Training Materials

Office:

- Online presentation on using the **Kadence** [desk booking system](#).